

AI-Generated Art as a Trading Zone: A Creolization between the MZ Generation and Traditional Culture

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Abstract

This paper examines how the concept of creolization is actually applied at the current time when generative artificial intelligence(AI) is being used in the field of art. It is addressed in the following three aspects: Firstly, we discuss a notion of 'trading zone' from the perspective of 'creolization'. Secondly, we explore how the trading zone can be formulated through the generative AI-based art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>. Thirdly, we examine how the MZ generation, which is treated as a special generation in the Korean society, experiences the 'creolization' through the generative AI-based art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>.

CCS Concepts

• **Social and professional topics** → Cultural characteristics.

Keywords

Generative artificial intelligence(AI), AI-generated art project, Hoengseong Hoedajisori, Creolization, Trading zone, Traditional culture, MZ generation

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1 Introduction

Creolization is a term referring to the process through which creole languages and cultures emerge. It has been discussed largely from a linguistic and social scientific perspective. Firstly, creolization has been intensively studied by linguists who wish to examine the emergence of a new language from two or more previous languages. According to them, 'creole' refers to the descendants of colonial

settlers from Europe. Each Creole has a mixed identity and speaks a mixed language. Therefore, linguists regarded 'creole' as a type of mixed language and referred to the process of mixing different languages with the term 'creolization' [Hymes, 1971]. Secondly, this concept has been used in various contexts by scholars studying cultural phenomena. According to them, creolization occurs when participants select particular elements from incoming cultures, endow these with meanings different from those they possessed in the original cultures, and then creatively merge these to create new varieties that supersede the prior forms [Cohen, 2007].

Creolization not only has complex meanings, but is also constantly being applied in new ways. Generative AI, which has recently become an issue, even contributes to creolization. The process of creating works of art using generative AI makes people's cultures and languages more diverse. When someone wants to create images, sounds, and videos using generative AI, he or she must write a prompt. A prompt is text entered to generate output from an AI model. Therefore, writing a prompt well means guiding the AI model well to produce results that meet the goal. When people write prompts to create the images, sounds, or videos they imagine, they inevitably experience the mixing of various cultures and languages.

This paper examines how the concept of creolization is actually applied at the current time when generative AI is being used in the field of art. It is addressed in the following three aspects: Firstly, we discuss a notion of 'trading zone' from the perspective of 'creolization'. Secondly, we explore how the trading zone can be formulated through the generative AI-based art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>. Thirdly, we examine how the MZ generation, which is treated as a special generation in the Korean society, experiences the 'creolization' through the generative AI-based art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>.

2 Creolization and Trading Zones

The concept of 'creolization' was first used by scholars to describe the process of language formation resulting from cultural contact and transmission. Linguists in the mid-20th century viewed creole as a type of language that emerges when pidgin is learned as mother tongue by later generations [Spitzer, 2003]. Pidgin usually refers to a simple contact language used as a means of communication among people who do not share a common language; Pidginization is the process by which pidgin is produced. Creole, on the other

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hand, can be referred to as pidgin expanded to the point where it can be used as a stable native language; Creolization is the process leading up to such a newly created natural language [Muysken and Smith, 1995].

The concept of creolization has evolved to have different meanings over time and has been used more widely in various academic fields. The anthropologist Ulf Hannerz applies the language continuum model to the apparent continuum of cultural repertoires of the world's societies. For him, creolization refers to the mixing of two or more previously separate traditions or cultures [Hannerz, 1987]. Sociologist Nicole Lapierre says that creolization is an unpredictable process that causes encounters, interference, shock, harmony and dissonance between cultures [Lapierre, 2004]. The physicist Peter Galison even notes that many experimental researchers and theorists in different scientific subcultures communicate in a mixed language that can be described as scientific creole [Galison, 1997].

In particular, Galison focused on anthropological research to solve problems of communication between heterogeneous scientific subcultures. It involves a 'trading zone' that enables trade between two villages with different languages and cultures. He applied the concept of trading zone, which is a linguistic, practical, and geographical space, to science [Galison, 1999]. The trading zone formed among heterogeneous scientific subcultures is like that formed between two villages with different languages. According to Galison, within a trading zone, two different groups can achieve local harmony despite their vast differences. A trading zone is a domain where simple contact languages are created and new constructed languages emerge [Galison, 1999]. The core competence of creolization comes from trading zones.

As a result, creolization and trading zones can be a tool that can effectively explain the process by which the local coordination among various disciplines takes place [Galison and Jones, 2014]. Even creolization and trading zones need to be actively utilized in the discussion of generative AI-based art. This is because in the process of writing prompts in generative AI, various cultures and languages can be mixed, and creolization and trading zones can be promoted.

3 Generative AI-based Art Project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>

Korean ancestors believed that death was merely a departure from the physical world, but a continued existence within it. 'Hoedajisori' is a traditional folk song sung during funeral rituals based on this afterlife view. This song was sung while mixing lime into the soil and tamping it down with one's feet to firm up the grave, and was one of the rituals to honor the deceased and their life. But it was not just for the purpose of memorialization. It also functioned as a cheerful work song for those who worked on graves, carrying coffins and building graves. 'Hoedajisori' was a song of life at the final phase of funeral, expressing community spirit as a link between life and death [Hoengseong Hoedajisori Archive, 2023].

In Korean, 'hoedaji' refers to the act of covering and stepping on lime-dusted soil, and 'sori' means a song. Among the many types of 'hoedaji' in Korea, the one that has been passed down from Jeongeum Village in Hoengseong County, Gandwon Province, is considered to have the most unique beauty in terms of melody and

movements. 'Hoengseong Hoedajisori' has served to comfort and restore the community, artistically elevating the resonance of life and death. In the contemporary world, where death is seen lighter, Hoedajisori conveys a witty meaning of death and resonates deeply.

The AI-generated art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori> [AI Contents Lab, 2024] is a student-driven production that recreates the traditional Korean folk song, 'Hoengseong Hoedajisori' into various contents based on the student's own initiatives of linking generative AI and traditional cultural resources. As shown in Figure 1, the project is centered on the Department of Culture and Content, Sangji University, and aims to build a "Contents One Campus" in collaboration between the Korea Creative Content Agency, the national organization for the Korean Content industry, media art production companies such as Amberin, and the Gangwon Cultural Foundation, a local cultural organization in Gangwon Province. Most importantly, through this project, students developed the ability to utilize generative AI, which has become a hot issue in recent years, and created their own works linked to 'Hoengseong Hoedajisori', a local traditional cultural resource.

The 25 students who participated in the project respectively planned a story, created images and sounds, and completed their own videos. In the process, they utilized AI image generators such as Midjourney for images, and SunoAI for sounds, and Runway for video finalization. In particular, the students studied various materials of 'Hoengseong Hoedajisori', comprehended its meanings, and experienced its melodies and movements with the help of a traditionalist. It provided a new opportunity for Korean university students who have never been exposed to traditional culture before. Furthermore, these new experiences were reflected upon in the prompts as the students worked with generative AI.

Young Koreans, the so-called MZ generation (Millennials+ Generation Z; born 1981-2010), have been living in a modernized society since birth. In fact, Korean traditional culture is even more foreign to them than American or European culture. They rarely use words that indicate traditional Korean heritage, such as Hanbok (traditional Korean costume), Hanok (traditional Korean house), and Sangyeo (traditional Korean bier), as well as 'Hoedajisori'. As they are too realistic and secularized, they sometimes resist the words like spirits and ghosts. They are even so close-minded and individualized that they see words like 'community' and 'communal consciousness' as something separate from them [Tracking 60 minutes, 2024].

However, the students in this project were obliged to interact with and use words that were unfamiliar to them. To generate the images and sounds they wanted through generative AI, they had to understand words that they rarely used in their daily lives, and sometimes even explain them to the AI so that it could understand their intentions. In this process, the two groups, the MZ generation and Korean traditional culture, were forced to come into contact, and a trading zone was naturally formed. Within this trading zone, the two disparate groups were able to achieve local harmony despite their enormous differences, which led to creolization, the intermingling of different cultures and languages.

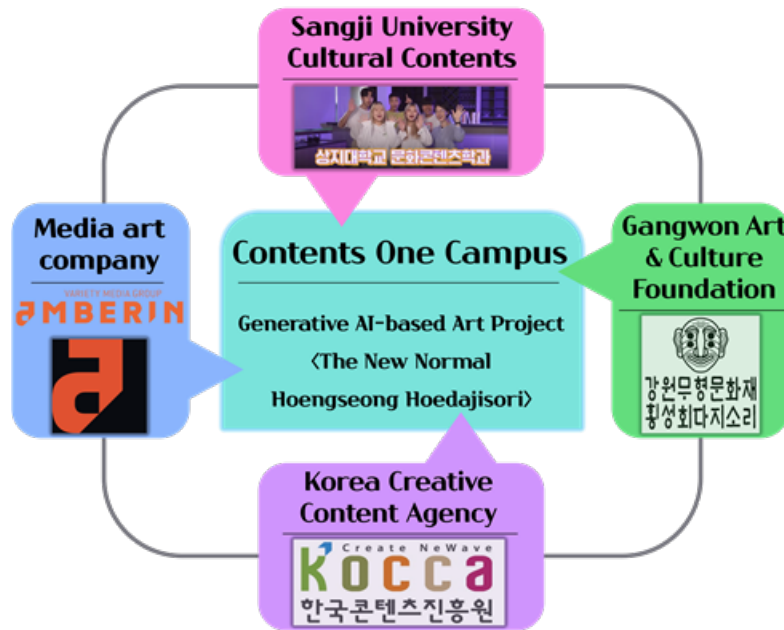


Figure 1: Partnering Organizations in the AI-generated Art Project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>.

4 Creolization between the MZ Generation and Traditional Culture in the AI-generated Art Project

Creolization connects the past and present through the reinterpretation of forms and meanings inherited from the past, as well as the creation of new forms that result from the combination of two or more cultures. This creolization also occurs between the MZ Generation and traditional Korean culture in the AI-generated art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori>. It manifests itself in the form of a consensus on the traditional afterlife view, or in the form of a conflict on the real life.

4.1 Consensual Creolization of Traditional Afterlife View

Hoengseong Hoedajisori acts as a link between life and death. It contains a strong afterlife view and reincarnation philosophy, where death is not the end but the beginning of entering another world. Injustices suffered in life remain after death, and sins committed in life are punished after death. Furthermore, someone can resolve injustices and punish the wrongdoer after death. This requires rituals of the living to comfort and guide the dead to another world.

In fact, this traditional afterlife view is foreign to the MZ generation in Korea. They have been exposed to developed science and technology since birth, so they tend to frame their thinking around what they can see and reject what cannot be scientifically proven. For the MZ generation, the AI-generated art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori> provides an opportunity for them to come into contact with the traditional afterlife view. In fact, out of the 25 students who participated in the project, more than half of them were not only interested in traditional afterlife, but they also used words associated with it. This suggests that a trading zone is

being created between the MZ generation and traditional Korean culture, and that contact languages are being used within it.

Indeed, one of the works in the project, *Sorikkun, Song of Yoonju* [Lim, 2024], actively embraces the traditional afterlife view and utilizes the contact languages associated with it. The work tells the story of Yoonju, a member of a family of Sorikkun who sings the Hoedajisori, accepting her family's mission of guiding spirits to the afterlife, resolving the grievances and resentments of the spirits and connecting this world and the afterlife. Here, Sorikkun is a person who sings traditional Korean folk songs very well, a term unfamiliar to the MZ generation. Interestingly, the creator of this work uses the word "Sorikkun" in a different way, as a person who sings a song that relieves the grudges and resentments of spirits, leading them to the afterlife. This can be seen as a kind of creolization, in that learners from a modern background have expanded the meaning of a traditional word while acquiring it.

Furthermore, as shown in Figure 2, the creator of this work uses concrete words in the prompts that refer to certain objects, such as Hoedajisori, Hanbok, Hanok, Janggu (traditional Korean musical instrument), spirits, ghosts, etc. This means that the Korean MZ generation is in contact with objects related to traditional culture and uses them in appropriate places in the process of creating AI-generated art. On the other hand, the creator of this work also uses abstract and conceptual words such as grievances, resentments, comfort, and peace in the prompts, as shown in Figure 3. This is a bit more complicated than using concrete words because students have to interpret their meaning and use them in context. However, through this work, the creator is embracing the traditional message that the spirits with grievances and resentments need to be comforted so that they can pass on to the afterlife, and offering an interpretation that this can lead to peace for the living. In this

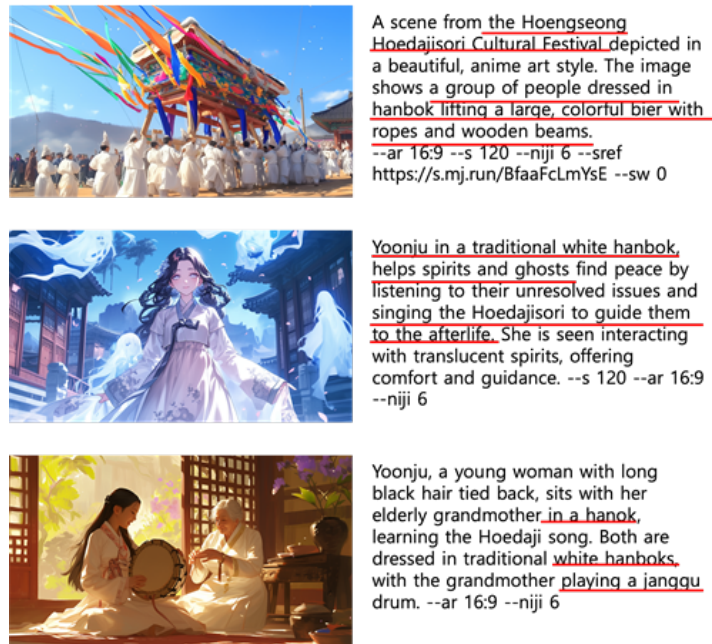


Figure 2: AI-generated images and concrete word-centered prompts used in *Sorikkun, Song of Yoonju*

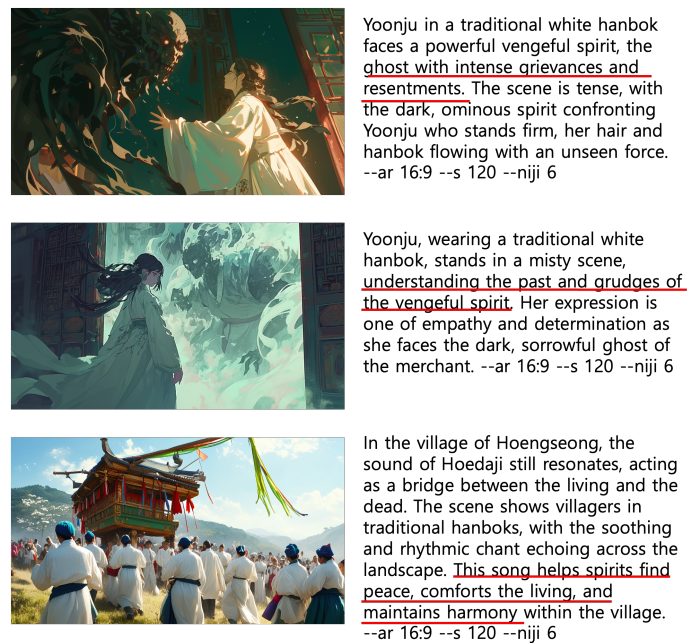


Figure 3: AI-generated images and abstract word-centered prompts used in *Sorikkun, Song of Yoonju*

way, the project creates a trading zone between the Korean MZ generation and traditional culture, and promotes creolization by creating a consensual message.

4.2 Conflictual Creolization of Real Life

Recent studies analyzing the MZ generation in Korea have mostly focused on their identity in terms of individualism and realism [Son and Kim, 2021]. They value individual tastes and preferences more than previous generations and actively utilize social media in their



In the evening rush hour, his footsteps looks heavy and exhausted, his full body is seen from behind, his back is zoomed in on, revealing the back of his head.

--ar 16:9 --cref <https://s.mj.run/WqIXqLXfJe0>
--cw 90 --stylize 200



With an evening city background, wearing wired earphones, he looks straight ahead with a lethargic and inert expression, in casual gray suit.

--ar 16:9 --cref <https://s.mj.run/hYvfp4k7C1Q>
--cw 10 --stylize 200



In the evening rush hour, at the Korean city, walking down the street while holding a cellphone, tired and empty eyes are watching on the cellphone, reality styles.

--ar 16:9 --cref <https://s.mj.run/xVWMenDYRc8> --cw 100 --stylize 200

Figure 4: AI-generated images and negative word-centered prompts used in *New Normal Hoedajisori*

lives. They also prefer indirect communication over direct dialogue with others and focus on personal and present values.

Unfortunately, their individualism and realism can often make them more isolated and helpless. In fact, the MZ generation in Korea, who neither work nor seek employment, is close to 700,000 people. Moreover, there are an estimated 540,000 people who are trapped in a labyrinth of isolation and seclusion due to prolonged periods of joblessness [Tracking 60 minutes, 2024]. Unlike previous generations, they have enjoyed an affluent life since birth, but they have lost their sense of community due to individualism and realism. The AI-generated art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori> provides an opportunity for the Korean MZ generation to question and collide with their lives.

One of the works in this project, *New Normal Hoedajisori* [Park, 2024], questions the current state of the MZ generation in Korea and calls for change. Furthermore, it suggests that the change should include the restoration of a sense of community, and that Hoengseong Hoedajisori could be the answer. Indeed, Hoedajisori has long served to comfort and restore communities by reminding people of someone's death. In a modern world where death is often taken lightly, Hoedajisori conveys a humorous meaning about death and carries a great resonance. Surprisingly, the creator of this work diagnoses the current MZ generation as dying, and hopes to revive them by using the meaning of community contained in Hoedajisori.

Furthermore, the creator of this work uses negative words such as heavy, exhausted, lethargic, inert, tired, empty, etc. in the prompts, as shown in Figure 4, as words that reflect their real life. This implies that the Korean MZ generation perceives their lives negatively and is in conflict with reality. On the other hand, as shown in Figure 5, the creator uses words related to traditional culture such as Bangsangssi mask, Hanbok, and bier in the prompts along with positive adjectives such as fantastic, refreshed, vibrant, beautiful, and trippy. This suggests that, paradoxically, the ritual of death can

restore and revitalize community. In particular, in this work, the Bangsangssi mask, which has four eyes and wards off evil spirits, is reinterpreted as a tool that clashes with real life and helps people move towards a better place.

5 Conclusion

Cultural creolization refers to the development of new traditions, aesthetics, and group identities that arise from the union of previously separate cultures. Cultural creolization can thus be understood as a more complex, creative, and adaptive process than assimilation into a single mainstream society or into a larger social order. Creolized societies combine two or more previously separate cultures in a new environment [Hannerz, 1992]. As we have seen, the AI-generated art project <New Normal Hoengseong Hoedajisori> shows this process of cultural creolization.

For Korean MZ generation, who have lived in a modernized society, Korean traditional culture is perceived as a separate world. However, the students who participated in this project formed a trading zone using a new tool called generative AI. Just as people of different cultures find points of contact to communicate with each other, students who ignored or rejected traditional culture were able to find a point of contact with traditional culture through this project and stimulate their curious minds. It is like connecting the past and present through the creation of new forms that result from the combination of two or more cultures.

Of course, AI's implications for cultural preservation and exchange are complex and multi-faceted. While AI can democratize access to cultural materials and enhance the preservation of endangered practices, it also poses risks related to bias, homogenization, and the exploitation of marginalized communities. Indeed, AI might contribute to cultural homogenization by promoting dominant cultures over less represented ones, raise questions about intellectual



Bangsangssi mask, with four eyes. The fantastic mask floats in mid-air. The hairs are red in color. Black background.

--ar 16:9 --cref <https://s.mj.run/U9W56LTctM>
--cw 80 --stylize 200



As the sunset fades, a man and a woman dressed in a white hanbok look up at the sky with a refreshed and vibrant expression.

--ar 16:9 --cref <https://s.mj.run/6ZPQ6rOwpzM>
--cw 85 --stylize 200



A group of people walking on the ground, as if lively stamping the earth with their feet. The image should be in psychedelic style, with vibrant colors and trippy effects, wearing a white hanbok, the traditional Korean attire. The beautiful bier is holding wooden poles and ropes, supporting the palanquin.

--ar 16:9 --cref https://s.mj.run/x_9FwbAsNX0
--cw 95 --stylize 200

Figure 5: AI-generated images and positive word-centered prompts used in *New Normal Hoedajisori*

property rights and the ownership of cultural heritage, and lead to biased representations of certain cultures [Yongjin, 2021].

Nonetheless, the students in this project have attempted to offset these risks. They were forced to interact with and use words that were unfamiliar to them in order to create their contents. As they typed prompts into generative AI, they created their own language by transforming or reinterpreting rarely used or newly learned words to suit their situations and contexts. Just as people from different cultures stabilize the simple mixed pidgin for communication between them and contextualize the more complex expanded creol, students contextualized the related words, while coming to terms with the newly encountered traditional culture or clashing with their real lives. It means that creolization is taking place within the trading zone of AI-generated art.

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